New Creation in Christ Jesus by Jeannette Musselman

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NEW CREATION IN CHRIST JESUS

Walking in Victory Over the Flesh

The bible tells us that the old is gone and the new has come. Our old man is gone and our new re-created man is alive. This is who we now are. This is our identity in Christ Jesus.

I am going to say some things that may challenge your mindset. I am not saying that your mindset is wrong. I am only suggesting that you may have a wrong mindset. Please allow Holy Spirit to reveal any wrong mindset to you that you may have. Don't resist Him. For years I prayed and asked God to turn my thinking that was upside down, right

side up and He did. I pray that you will make this your prayer today. When the Holy Spirit began to change my mindset, I almost resisted Him but then I prayed "Lord if this is truth, I want to believe it. Please set me free from the lies that I have believed." We need God to change our mindset. Only He can do this but we have to give Him the permission to do it.

Isaiah 61:1-3 says that Jesus came to set the captives free. When we believe the lies of the enemy, he is holding us captive but Jesus wants to free us so that our believing will be right. Our actions will follow our believing so it is very important that our believing is right. He wants to replace the lies that we are believing with truth but we have to

cooperate with His Spirit in order for Him to do this.

I had a mindset that needed to be changed. When I was younger and before I became a Christian, I saw God the Father as a harsh judge who was ready to pronounce judgment on me the moment I did something wrong. After I became a Christian, God began to change my mindset/my wrong perception of Him and He replaced it with truth. I don't see God the Father like that anymore. I now see Him as a loving Father who wants His very best for me. I know I can jump up on His lap at any time and receive His hugs and kisses. I can come to Him with any problem, or need in my life, and ask Him for advice, direction and provision. I can come boldly before His throne of grace to

receive help and grace in times of need. This is how I now see Him. This is how He wants us to see Him.

Saul had a mindset that needed to be changed. Saul was on his way to Damascus to arrest followers of Jesus and to imprison them. Saul was brought up under the law. He was a Pharisee of Pharisees. He was very zealous for the law and because of his zeal for God he was persecuting those who believed in Jesus and who were embracing the grace of God. Jesus appeared to him and said "Saul, Saul, why do you persecute **me**?"

Saul's believing was wrong resulting in wrong actions. Saul's mindset was drastically changed and he was transformed by his encounter with Jesus. After his Damascus Road experience

with Jesus he became a follower of Jesus and stopped persecuting Christians. Instead he began to preach the message of grace.

Peter had an encounter with God that transformed and drastically changed his mindset. Peter was also very diligent in obeying the law of Moses. One day Peter fell into a trance and he saw heaven open up and something like a large sheet come down from heaven to earth which contained all kinds of unclean animals, reptiles and birds. According to the law of Moses, the Israelites were not allowed to eat them or they would be unclean before God. In the trance (vision), God told Peter to kill and eat them and Peter said he would not because he had never eaten anything impure or unclean. God told Peter not to call anything impure

that He has made clean. This happened three times (see Acts 10:9-16). God gave this vision to Peter to prepare him for what God was about to reveal to him. God was extending salvation to the Gentiles by sending Peter to Cornelius' house, who was a Gentile, to bring them the message of salvation. Peter thought that salvation belonged only to the Jews but God changed his mindset.

So allow the Holy Spirit to change your mindset if it is not in accordance with His Word. You may not even realize you have a mindset that needs changing. You can ask the Holy Spirit to reveal any mindset to you that needs changing. It would be good if you did that now.

I want to talk to you about the old man, the flesh and the sinful nature. I was

taught that the flesh and the sinful nature are separate; that Jesus dealt with the sinful nature on the cross but that we still have a flesh to fight. If that is true, then Jesus didn't fully deal with sin.

I don't see anywhere in the Bible that I am to fight my flesh. **I do see** that I am to draw near to God, resist the devil and he will flee from me. When I draw near to God, I am resisting the devil. **I do see** that I am to fight the good fight of faith and my fight of faith is to believe that the old sinful fleshly man is dead and buried, that Jesus defeated the devil on my behalf and I have been raised with Jesus a new creation in Him.

In 1 Corinthians 15:31 Paul says that he dies every day. Paul is not fighting his

flesh but he remembers and believes every day that he was crucified with Christ; that his old sinful fleshly man is dead, that he is a new creation in Christ and that's how he overcame when the enemy tried to tempt him to sin.

The enemy also used temptation with Jesus. Jesus defeated the devil, who was tempting Him, with the Word of God. Jesus did not fight His flesh. He knew who He was and He walked with His Father. He kept His eyes on His Father and quoted the Word of God and He was able to successfully resist the enemy.

When the subject of the flesh is taught, usually the scriptures in Romans 7:14-25 are mentioned where Paul is describing his struggle with his flesh but in these scriptures Paul is referring to

his struggle with his flesh before he became a Christian, while he was still living under the law, not after he became a Christian.

Let's look more closely at that scripture reference.

Romans 7:14-25 "We know that the law is spiritual; but I am unspiritual, sold as a slave to sin. I do not understand what I do. For what I want to do I do not do, but what I hate I do. And if I do what I do not want to do, I agree that the law is good. As it is, it is no longer I myself who do it, but it is sin living in me. I know that nothing good lives in me, that is, in my sinful nature. For I have the desire to do what is good, but I cannot carry it out. For what I do is not the good I want to do, no, the evil I do not

want to do—this I keep on doing. Now if I do what I do not want to do, it is no longer I who do it, but it is sin living in me that does it. So I find this law at work: When I want to do good, evil is right there with me. For in my inner being I delight in God's law; but I see another law at work in the members of my body, waging war against the law of my mind and making me a prisoner of the law of sin at work within my members. What a wretched man I am! Who will rescue me from **<u>this body of death?</u>** Thanks be to God -- through Jesus Christ our Lord! (emphasis added)

Paul was a Pharisee and according to his upbringing was blameless, yet the very law he trusted in still condemned him **before he was a Christian**. Paul is talking about himself dealing with his

flesh **prior to his salvation**, while he was still living under the law, still having the sinful nature. Paul was speaking of himself not in the context of being a Christian but in the context of his life prior to being a Christian. In Philippians 3:1-9 Paul says that when he was walking under the law he put confidence in the flesh thinking that the law would bring righteousness but found out that only grace can produce true righteousness by faith. Paul says in verse 14 above "I am unspiritual", yet we know that Paul was alive to God **after salvation**. He had the nature of God in him. He could not be unspiritual since he was now born again. He goes on to say that he was sold as a slave to sin. This was true of Paul's life prior to salvation but not after. In verse18 Paul

says that he knows that nothing good lives in him, that is in his sinful fleshly nature. We know that Jesus lived in Paul and Jesus is good, so something good did live in Paul but not before salvation. In verse 24 he says "What a wretched man I am**!**". This was true of Paul's life prior to salvation but not after. He goes on to ask a question "Who will rescue me from **<u>this body of death?</u>**". Then he gives the answer in verse 25. He says: "Thanks be to God – through Jesus Christ our Lord**!**". He says that Jesus rescued him. Paul was saying that he could not rescue himself from the law or from the sinful fleshly nature and he says that Jesus Christ can and will rescue everyone who comes to Him. When you believe in Jesus, you are a new creation. The old is

gone and the new has come (see 2 Corinthians 5:17).

The body of death that Jesus rescued Paul from, and that we are rescued from as believers, was the Old Covenant law of Moses. He did this by fully obeying the law for us and in His redemptive work He established the New Covenant of grace which is the gospel that we preach today. As long as we walk under the Old Covenant law of Moses, we will struggle with our old sinful fleshly man.

Jesus fully obeyed the law for us so that we can walk delivered from sin. Jesus fully obeyed the law for believers because we could not fully obey it ourselves. It was put into effect as a school master to help us realize that we could not fully obey it and that we

needed a Savior who is Jesus Christ. Now that we believe in Him, the law has done its work and we are no longer under the law but under the new covenant of grace that Jesus established for us in His redemptive work.

If the law of Moses could make us righteous and save us from our sins, then it was not necessary for Jesus to come and die for our sins. Paul clearly tells us the struggle that he had with sin when he was walking under the law.

Since Paul was in Christ when he wrote this, since he was already crucified with Christ, the sinful fleshly nature was no longer alive in him. He was dead to sin and alive to God. Paul was not talking about himself as a Christian struggling with his flesh but rather he was giving us

a picture of the struggles he had trying to obey the law without Christ in his life. That's self-righteousness. God does not accept self-righteousness. Besides, we cannot fully obey the law. We will never be made righteous by trying to obey the law. We cannot earn the righteousness that God accepts from trying to obey the law.

Believers often struggle to try to obey the law in order to become more righteous. We need to stop this. By doing this, we are mixing law and grace together which is actually mixing our self-righteousness with the righteousness that Jesus gives to us. They don't mix. Mixing these things together will create a lukewarm struggling Christian who will always be sin conscious and never getting free.

The moment we believed in Jesus, He gave us His very own righteousness. He made us righteous. We are as righteous as Jesus is. We cannot become anymore righteous. The righteousness that comes from believing in Jesus is a free gift. It cannot be earned, merited or deserved. We receive it by grace through faith in Jesus Christ.

In Romans 7:24 Paul says "What a wretched man I am! Who will rescue me from **this body of death?**" The law is the body that causes people to sin and it brings death and condemnation. Paul, talking about himself prior to salvation, is saying who will rescue me from the law. Paul says, Jesus will rescue me and infers that Jesus will rescue all who come to Him.

In Christ Jesus we are no longer under the law of Moses. We are under the New Covenant of grace that Jesus established for us. Grace is a free gift. It cannot be earned, merited or deserved. It can only be received so please embrace the grace of God.

Can you pray right now and ask the Father, in the Name of Jesus, to help you by the power of His Spirit to walk in grace and grace alone.

Titus 2:12 says that Grace teaches us (or we can say, helps us) to say "no" to ungodliness and worldly passions and teaches (or helps) us to live self-controlled, upright and Godly lives in this present age. We need the grace of God to help us when temptations come. Paul preached the Gospel of grace and he

walked in victory over his old sinful fleshly man.

I would like to share a short testimony with you on how God helped me to overcome something in my life.

I had a problem with rage before I was a Christian that popped up every once in a while. Sometime in the first six months to a year after my salvation, rage popped up and I verbally abused my children. They had done something and it had really pushed my buttons so I let them have it with harsh words. In my rage, I went into my bedroom, laid on my bed face down and started pounding the bed. In my rage, I talked to God right there and I said something like this: "Dear God, I don't want to act like this. It is hurting my children and this is not how

You want me to act. Help me never to do this again." I never did. However, there was one time where it could have gone either way but God came and rescued me and my children and I was able to resist the enemy. I praise God for this victory.

In my study of the Word of God regarding this subject and the revelation that the Holy Spirit has given to me I have come to the conclusion that the old man, the flesh and the sinful nature are the same.

If you have been struggling with your flesh and not doing so great in overcoming it, please pay careful attention as the understanding of this truth will show you how to walk in the victory that Jesus already gave you. I'm

not saying that you won't be tempted and even fail at times but when you get a revelation that you are a new creation in Christ Jesus **and you get firmly established in this truth**, it will set you free. It is the truth that sets us free. Struggling in our own efforts will never set us free.

There is a prayer in Ephesians 1:17-19 that you can pray for revelation. Paul prayed this prayer over the Ephesian Church regularly. I have prayed this prayer regularly over my life and my loved ones. You can pray this prayer now.

Father, in Jesus' Name, I ask that You would give me the Spirit of wisdom and revelation so that I may know You better. I pray also that You would

enlighten the eyes of my heart in order that I may know the hope to which You have called me, the riches of Your glorious inheritance in the saints, and Your incomparably great power for me.

By praying this prayer we are depending on the Holy Spirit to bring the revelation and not on our own intellect to understand it. Spiritual truths only come by revelation.

We don't have to serve the old sinful fleshly man anymore because he has been crucified with Christ and has passed away. He has been buried with Christ. He is no longer alive. **The only life your flesh has is the life you give it.** If you still think you have a flesh to fight, then you have given life to your flesh.

Galatians 2:20 "**I have been crucified with Christ and I no longer live, but Christ lives in me.** The life I live in the body, I live by faith in the Son of God, who loved me and gave himself for me." (emphasis added)

KJV says "I live by the faith of the Son of God".

I don't put my faith in my faith. Rather, I put my faith in Jesus Christ and what He has done for me.

Did you notice that our crucifixion with Christ is past tense? We **were** crucified with Christ. When? When we got born again. God wants you to firmly grab ahold of this truth. You are a new creation! A brand new man! The old is gone and the new has come **but you must believe it** and walk by faith in

what the Word of God says about you and not by sight. It says "you have been crucified with Christ and your old sinful fleshly man no longer lives but Christ lives in you".

It may appear that the old man is still alive at times but don't walk by sight. We are to walk by faith in what the Word of God says. In fact, we walk by His (Jesus) faith. Jesus said on the cross that "It is finished". This is a faith walk that we are on with Jesus.

1 Peter 2:24 "He himself bore **our sins** in his body on the tree, so that we might die to sins and live for righteousness; **by his wounds you have been healed.**" (emphasis added)

This scripture says that by his wounds we have been healed. What are we

healed from? This scripture says that Jesus bore our sins so that we might die to sins and live for righteousness. The word "healed" is a verb. It is an action and it means to cure, heal, make whole. By the wounds of Jesus, we have been cured from sins so that we can live for God.

Colossians 2:6-7 "So then, **just as you received Christ Jesus as Lord**, **continue to live in him**, rooted and built up in him, strengthened in the faith as you were taught, and overflowing with thankfulness." (emphasis added)

We received Jesus as our Savior and Lord by grace through faith in Him. Remember that grace is unearned, unmerited, undeserved favor with God. We simply believed in Him and we were

saved. At salvation we hadn't done anything to save ourselves except receive His free gift of salvation by believing in Him. We overcome the old sinful fleshly man the same way: by grace through faith in Him. We believe in Jesus and in His finished work. We believe that He dealt with the sin problem in our lives and that the old sinful fleshly man is dead and buried. Paul says "Thanks be to God – through Jesus Christ" I am delivered from that old sinful fleshly man.

When the old sinful fleshly man tries to rear its ugly head we say "No, you have been nailed to the cross and buried with Christ. You are dead and have no power over me". We will need to persistently resist **the temptations of the enemy** who will try to make us think that the

old sinful fleshly man is still alive. We resist these temptations **by meditating on the truth** that we have been crucified with Christ and our old sinful fleshly man no longer lives but Christ lives in us. The new re-created man with God's divine nature lives on the inside of us. That's who we now are. We need to get our minds renewed with this truth that we are a new creation as it will set us free. When Jesus was raised from the dead, we were raised with Him and the moment we believed in Jesus as our personal Savior and Lord **this became a reality in our life**, but we have to believe this.

Prior to Adam's sin, there was no sinful nature, no old man and no flesh to contend with. Let that sink in.

In the Old Testament, sin was sin. There was no separation of the sinful nature and the flesh. When Adam sinned, his eyes were opened to both good and evil and sin entered him. Everyone born after Adam was born with a sinful nature which is what the New Testament scriptures refer to as the old man and the flesh. The old man and the flesh came at the same time the sinful nature entered. They are the same. The flesh and the old man are the sinful nature.

The moment we believe in Jesus, we return to the way it was before sin entered mankind. There was no flesh, no old man and no sinful nature before Adam sinned. He simply walked with God.

In Genesis 1:28 God gave Adam dominion to rule over the fish of the sea and the birds of the air and over every living creature that moves on the ground. Adam ruled over these things. In Christ, we have been given authority to trample on snakes and scorpions and to overcome all the power of the enemy (see Luke 10:19). He is under our feet. We are above and not beneath. In other words, we have been given authority over the enemy of our soul. We are his master, not the other way around. When the enemy comes to tempt us, or make us think that our old sinful fleshly man is still alive, we need to trample on him for he is under our feet and say "No". We need to take our authority in Jesus' Name and command him to leave. He must bow to the Name of Jesus. Of

course, we do all of this, not in our own power, but in the power of the Holy Spirit. He lives in us 24/7 to help us. We can call upon Him at any time. You can call upon the Holy Spirit right now and ask for His help to draw near to God so that you can resist the enemy of your soul.

Holy Spirit I thank you that you are my Helper and I call upon Your help right now to draw me near to God and to resist the enemy of my soul. Thank You Holy Spirit.

When Cain killed Abel, the flesh was present in his sinful nature. The Lord did not look with favor on Cain's offering as He did on Abel's offering. God accepted Abel's offering because Abel chose to believe in Him. God rejected

Cain's offering because Cain was walking in unbelief and because of his unbelief jealousy rose up in him and he killed Abel. Cain's believing was not right which resulted in wrong behavior. **The root was Cain's wrong believing.** Jealousy is of the flesh which comes from the sinful nature because sin had entered the world.

Genesis 4:7 (God talking to Cain) "If you **do** what is right, will you not be accepted? But if you do not **do** what is right, sin is crouching at your door, it desires to have you, **but you must master it.**" (emphasis and parenthesis added)

I want to show you from a scripture in the New Testament that the word "do" is to believe.

John 6:27-29 “Do not work for food that spoils, but for food that endures to eternal life, which the Son of Man will give you. On him God the Father has placed his seal of approval.” Then they asked him, “What must we **do** to **do** the works God requires?” Jesus answered, “The work of God is this: **to believe** in the one he has sent.” (emphasis added)

From this scripture, we see that the “doing” is to believe in Jesus Christ.

God said to Cain “If you do right” which was referring to his believing. In other words God was telling Cain that if he believed right, he would do right but if he did not believe right, sin was crouching at his door **but he must master it by believing right**. We know that Cain did not take heed to God’s

word. His believing was not right which resulted in him murdering his brother.

When God spoke to Cain, He did not make a distinction between the sinful nature and the flesh. Sin was sin. The sinful nature was not separate from the flesh. God, however, did point out to Cain that his believing was wrong and because of his wrong believing **sin** was crouching at the door.

It is very important for us to believe right **because when we believe right we will live right and master sin**. Cain believed wrong and wrong actions followed his wrong believing. Sin was conceived in his heart before he took action.

God has not taken our free will away from us. We can choose to give into

temptation, give life to the old man and live like the devil but if you truly want to walk in the victory that Jesus died to give you then use your free will to:

1. Believe that the old man is gone and the new man has come.
2. Give attention to the Word of God so that transformation will take place.
3. Ask the Holy Spirit to help you walk in the new creation that God made you to be.
4. Embrace the grace of God and allow God's grace to teach you to live right.

We can walk in victory over our old sinful fleshly man in Christ with the Holy Spirit's help as we are a new creation.

Our new re-created man is led not by our flesh **but by the Holy Spirit**. So co-operate with Him, listen to His voice, fellowship with Holy Spirit, get to know Him, walk with Him and do what He says. **He is your friend and will help you.**

Colossians 2:11-12 "In him you were also circumcised in the putting off of the sinful nature, not with a circumcision done by the hands of men (which is physical) but with the circumcision done by Christ (which is spiritual), having been buried with him in baptism and raised with him **through your faith** in the power of God, who raised him from the dead." (emphasis and parenthesis added)

If you are a believer, you have been circumcised by Christ. Just like in natural circumcision where a piece of flesh is cut away and removed, in Christ that old sinful fleshly man has been cut away and nailed to the cross. It was crucified with Christ. It died with Christ. It was buried with Christ and through your faith in the power of God you were raised a new creation in Christ with His nature of love. You now have His nature. A completely brand new nature. You are a brand new creation.

This is truth that we need to grasp and walk in. We need to keep this truth before us so when the devil tries to tempt us and tell us that our old sinful fleshly man is still alive and living, we can say "NO! He is dead and buried with Christ and I am a new creation. We

defeat the devil with the Word of God just like Jesus defeated him by quoting the Word. Every time Jesus quoted the Word, the devil left him.

This is how we will walk delivered from the old sinful fleshly man.

I am telling you these things so that you will believe right and believe in accordance with God's Word. When you believe right, you will live right and walk in victory. When you believe wrong, you will live wrong and walk in defeat. You may not have instant success but keep believing right and right actions will eventually follow you. Faith comes by hearing and hearing the Word of God.

Colossians 2:13 "When you were dead in your sins and in the uncircumcision of

your sinful nature, God made you alive with Christ."

God did it. We are alive with Christ because God made us alive with him by cutting away the old sinful fleshly man and making us a brand new creation. The old is gone!!! The new has come!!! **We haven't been made new with a part of our old still alive.**

How do we live this new life that God gave us?

Romans 12:1-2 "Therefore, I urge you, brothers, in view of God's mercy, to **offer your bodies** as living sacrifices, holy and pleasing to God—this is your spiritual act of worship. Do not conform any longer to the pattern of this world, but **be transformed by the renewing of your mind**. Then you will be able to

test and approve what God's will is—his good, pleasing and perfect will." (emphasis added)

As a new creation in Christ Jesus, this scripture tells us two very important things:

1. To offer our bodies to God.
2. To get our minds renewed with the Word of God.

When we do these two things transformation will take place in our hearts. By doing this, we are simply cooperating with the Holy Spirit.

We are a three part being. God is a three part being and He is also a Spirit. We are made in the image of God. We are a spirit. We possess a soul which consists

of our mind, will and emotions which flow out of our heart. We live in a body.

Our soul is the part that we need to get renewed with the Word of God so that we will no longer be led by our emotions, our own will and our own thoughts but rather be led by the Holy Spirit who will teach us the Word of God and how to believe right so that we will live right.

Just like our spirit got saved by grace through faith in Jesus Christ, our soul is saved the same way.

We need the grace of God in our lives. If we remove the grace of God from our lives and go back under the law to earn our salvation, it will result in all kinds of sinning.

There is a scripture in Jude that has been misinterpreted. Some people say that the grace of God is giving people the license to sin.

Jude:4 “For certain men whose condemnation was written about long ago have secretly slipped in among you. They are godless men, who **change** the grace of our God **into** a license for immorality and deny Jesus Christ our only Sovereign and Lord.” (emphasis added)

As I studied out this scripture, I looked up the Greek for the words “change” and “into” in the above scripture.

Change means to remove.

Into means resulting in.

So when we remove the Grace of God, it will result in sinning.

Some people are using this scripture and are saying that some preachers, who are preaching grace, are giving people the license to sin when, in fact, this scripture is actually saying the opposite. Grace is not a license to sin but the complete opposite.

Again, I want to mention Titus 2:12 which says that Grace teaches us to say "No to ungodliness and worldly passions and it teaches us to live self-controlled, upright and godly lives in this present age". If we give into temptation, we need to run to the grace of God. The grace of God is Jesus. Jesus is the Word. When we run to the grace of God, we are running to Jesus, the Word of God, to

teach us so that we will believe right and when we believe right, we will live right.

A child in the natural messes up a lot especially during his toddler, childhood and teenage years. This is when parents need to be patient with them in their mistakes and this is when they teach them so that when they reach adulthood, they will have a firm foundation on which to build the rest of their lives. It is the same with our spiritual growth. We need to go to the Word of God and allow the Holy Spirit to teach us valuable foundational lessons throughout our young years as a Christian so that we will be firmly established upon the rock of Jesus Christ and remain with Him to the very end of our lives.

When a little boy is told that he is bad because of something he has done and if he is told it often enough, he believes that he is bad and bad actions will follow. However, if he is told that he had done a bad thing but that he is still a good boy and Mommy and Daddy still love him even though he had done a bad thing, that little boy will grow up believing that he is right and his actions will follow what he believes about himself. Because he believes that he is right, he will do right.

When we believe that we are right with God and that He loves us unconditionally, our actions will follow our right believing.

The bible says to grow up in our salvation now that we have tasted that

the Lord is good. We grow up by studying and meditating on the Word of God and by being a part of a bible study where truth is being taught. The more we get the Word of God into our hearts and coming out of our mouths, the more truth we will receive; the more we will believe the Word and the more victory we will walk in. Let the Word of God permeate your heart and bring transformation.

God is not looking for perfection because no one can achieve this. There was only one perfect person and that person was Jesus. However, we can grow in more and more levels of perfection. What God is interested in is that we are growing in our love walk and growing in our knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus

Christ; that as we look back over our lives, we see growth and victories.

Jesus had the Word of God in His heart so that He could use it as a weapon against satan's temptations.

It takes time to get our minds renewed with the Word of God. God understands this. We are born into the Kingdom of God as a spiritual infant who doesn't know anything but to cry, eat and poop. Just like earthly parents don't want their baby to remain an infant forever, God wants his babies to grow up as well. He wants us to read, study and meditate on the Word of God so that He can teach us to believe right; so that transformation, growth and right living will be our portion. There is victory in Christ and

we can master sin when we believe right.

There's a song called "You've Already Won". One line says "I'm fighting a battle you've already won". Jesus already won the battle over sin. Now it's up to us to choose to believe this. Jesus has done it all but now we choose to walk in that victory. We may not walk perfectly but as we keep believing, keep drawing close to God and keep resisting the temptations in His power and strength, the enemy must flee. You may get the victory a little at a time. Rejoice in that victory and keep believing for total victory.

If you need to run to the Father again and again and again and again, then do it. Keep running to Him and don't stop.

Run into His arms of forgiveness, love and grace. Allow Him to pull that stronghold of wrong believing down. Hide in His Presence as He does it. Confess that Jesus is your Stronghold because that's who He is. Meditate on that truth.

Some may refer to our unrenewed mind as our sinful flesh. But is it? Or is it that we are baby Christians who are childish in our thinking and believing and need to get our minds renewed so that we will think and believe right. I think that our unrenewed mind simply needs to be renewed. By getting our minds renewed with the Word of God, it will certainly help us to resist the old sinful fleshly man and keep him dead.

The bible says in Hebrews 4:12 that the Word of God is living and active. It is sharper than any doubled-edged sword, it penetrates even to dividing soul and spirit, joints and marrow and it judges the thoughts and attitudes of the heart. The Word of God becomes alive in us as we study and meditate on it; as we take it in and apply it to our everyday lives. It is living and it will actively work on our behalf to bring about the desired results.

James 1:19-21 "My dear brothers, take note of this. Everyone should be quick to listen, slow to speak and slow to become angry, for man's anger does not bring about the righteous life that God desires. Therefore, get rid of all moral filth and the evil that is so prevalent and humbly accept the word planted in you, which can save you."

It is the Word of God that saves us (spirit, soul and body). It is the Word of God that will bring transformation to us.

James 1:22-25 "Do not merely listen to the word, and so deceive yourselves. **Do** what it says. Anyone who listens to the word but does not **do** what it says is like a man who looks at his face in a mirror and, after looking at himself, goes away and immediately forgets what he looks like. But the man who looks intently into the perfect law that gives freedom, and continues to **do** this, not forgetting what he has heard, but doing it – he will be blessed in what he **does**." (emphasis added)

Remember the word "do" as interpreted by Jesus in John 6:26-29 means to believe. When we look at the above

scripture with this understanding, it is saying that we are not just to merely listen to the word **but believe it**. If we don't believe it, we will forget it. If we believe it, we will remember it and right living will be the result of our right believing.

Matthew 7:24-27 "Therefore everyone who hears these words of mine and puts them into practice is like a wise man who built his house on the rock. The rain came down, the streams rose, and the winds blew and beat against that house; yet it did not fall, because it had its **foundation** on the rock. But everyone who hears these words of mine and does not put them into practice is like a foolish man who built his house on sand. The rain came down, the streams rose, and the winds blew

and beat against that house, and it fell with a great crash." (emphasis added)

If we believe the word of God, we will put it into practice and we will obtain the desired results.

Christianity **is all about believing what Jesus has done for us**. We believe in Him as our personal Savior and Lord. **Now we need to believe He has given us everything we need for life and godliness so that we can live a victorious life over sin and temptations. He has already dealt with the sin problem. Get your mind off of your sin and fix your mind and heart on Jesus.**

In 2 Chronicles 20, a great army was coming against Israel so Jehoshaphat prayed to God declaring that He rules

over all the kingdoms of the nations; that power and might were in His hand and no one could withstand Him. As he prayed he said that they had no power to face this vast army that was attacking them; that they didn't know what to do but their eyes were upon God to help them.

God answered his prayer through a prophet and said in verses 15-17 "Listen, King Jehoshaphat and all who live in Judah and Jerusalem! This is what the Lord says to you: Do not be afraid or discouraged because of this vast army, for the battle is not yours, but God's. Tomorrow march down against them. You will not have to fight this battle. Take up your positions; stand firm and see the deliverance the Lord will give you, O Judah and Jerusalem. Do not be

afraid; do not be discouraged. Go out to face them tomorrow, and the Lord will be with you."

The Lord is telling us the same thing regarding our old sinful fleshly man. He is telling us not to be afraid or discouraged for the battle is not ours, but God's.

Jehoshaphat appointed men to sing to the Lord and to praise Him for the splendor of His holiness. As they went out at the head of the army they began to sing and praise, and the Lord set ambushes against their enemy and God defeated their enemies.

In verse 16, the prophet told Jehoshaphat that the battle is not yours, but God's.

In verse 20, Jehoshaphat told the people to put their faith in God and they would be upheld.

In verse 28, they praised God with great joy for the victory.

As they listened to the Word of God and did what the Lord told them to do, their enemies were defeated.

By praising God, they got their eyes on God and off of their enemy. It is the same with us today. We need to get our eyes off of our sin and fix our eyes on Jesus. Jesus has already fought and won the battle of sin for us. Now, we need to believe this so that we can walk in the victory that Jesus died to give us. He gave us the victory over sin and over the flesh. This is a finished work. Now it is a matter of getting our minds renewed

with the Word of God so that we will believe it.

When we think we still have a flesh to fight, it creates a sin consciousness in us. **We get focused on the sin in our lives and by doing this we give it power**. When we refer to ourselves as a sinner, we are saying that's who we are. I don't ever refer to myself as a sinner because what does a sinner do? A sinner goes out and sins. If we want to live right, we need to start declaring who we really are. We are the righteousness of God in Christ Jesus. If we really believe we have been made righteous, we will live right. If we believe that we are a sinner, then we will live like a sinner. Even when we have just done something wrong, we need to declare that we are the righteousness of God in Christ Jesus. We

are to walk by faith in the Word of God and not by sight. This is our declaration and as we continue to declare this, we will eventually believe it and right living will result.

We are no longer slaves to sin but slaves to Christ. We will be slaves to whatever or whoever we give our attention to.

2 Peter 2:19b "For a man is a slave to whatever has mastered him."

Just because we made a mistake and gave into temptation, it doesn't mean we are a mistake. We are all a work in progress. There is grace in our mistakes. Receive God's grace in your mistakes.

When urges come, die to that urge. Put the old man to death by quoting the Word of God. When the urge comes to

sin sexually, to gossip, to over eat, to slander, to get angry, etc. just say “No”. Tell the old man he is dead and buried and that you are a new creation in Christ.

Maybe you are doing this and getting some victory but then you give in to an urge. Repent, get right back up, throw off the condemnation and continue running the race with perseverance. God is not looking for perfection but He is looking for growth. There is danger when we are not growing. 2 Peter 3:18 says “to grow in the grace and knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ”.

The bible says to draw near to God, resist the devil and he will flee. When we draw near to God, we are

empowered to resist the urges and temptations the devil brings.

Let's look at the prodigal son and his father. The son left to go into the world and live like the world. His living was wrong and extravagant which resulted in him losing the inheritance his father gave him when he left. Because of this wrong lifestyle, he ended up living with the pigs and longed to eat what the pigs ate because he was so hungry.

There are consequences when we sin. Sin brings negative consequences and punishes us. If we use our free will to insist on doing things our way and living like the world does, our sin will eventually punish us. God allows this. God disciplines those He loves. Discipline means to correct, teach and

train. If we resist God's discipline and insist on going our own way, sin's consequences will make life unpleasant and painful just like the prodigal son. However, if we submit to God's discipline, it will produce a peaceful life and right living.

The son chose to return home to live with his father. The father saw his son's repented heart. He saw that his son **had left his old life behind** and was returning home.

Just like the father of the prodigal son welcomed him home with open arms, God the Father's arms are always open wide for us to run into, repent and receive His forgiveness and love.

Hebrews 13:21 says that God will equip us with everything good for doing his

will and will work in us what is pleasing to Him through Jesus Christ.

So what do we do if we are struggling with sin but at the same time want to do things God's way? This scripture says that **God will** equip us and work in us what is pleasing to Him.

You can talk to the Holy Spirit right now and ask Him to equip you and work in you what is pleasing to Him.

Let's look at Hebrews Chapter 11.

Hebrews 11:1-2 "Now faith is being sure of what we hope for and certain of what we do not see. This is what the ancients were commended for."

As long as we don't see the results we are longing for, we need to **continue** to employ faith. We need to **continue** to

keep our faith active. We need to **continue** to believe what God says even though we are not **yet** seeing the desired results. If we **continue to believe** God for victory, it will come. Don't quit. Don't give up. Keeping believing.

It may look like that old sinful fleshly man is alive but keep walking by faith to believe he is dead. Don't condemn yourself as that will only make things worse. Run to the Father's arms, repent and receive His forgiveness and love. Stand up **in the power of the Holy Spirit** and keep walking by faith.

Hebrews goes on to tell us how the ancients used their faith to obtain great victories. You can read this whole Chapter but I want to jump down to verses 32 to 39.

Hebrews 11:32-39a "And what more shall I say? I do not have time to tell about Gideon, Barak, Samson, Jephthah, David, Samuel and the prophets, who through faith conquered kingdoms, administered justice, and gained what was promised; who shut the mouths of lions, quenched the fury of the flames, and escaped the edge of the sword; whose weakness was turned to strength; and who became powerful in battle and routed foreign armies. Women received back their dead raised to life again. Others were tortured and refused to be released, so that they might gain a better resurrection. Some faced jeers and flogging, while still others were chained and put in prison. They were stoned; they were sawed in two, they were put to death by the sword. They went about

in sheepskins and goatskins, destitute, persecuted and mistreated – the world was not worthy of them. They wandered in deserts and mountains, and in caves and holes in the ground. **These were all commended for their faith**." (emphasis added)

The scripture says through faith they conquered. Through faith in the finished work of Jesus Christ, we will walk in victory over the old sinful fleshly man as well. Jesus has already conquered the old man for us. Now we need to believe this and employ faith.

It also says that some were tortured, persecuted, imprisoned, put to death, etc. because of their faith.

When we overcome sin through faith in the finished work of Jesus Christ, we will

also be able to stand up through that same faith and overcome other pressures that the enemy brings like persecution, etc.

Hebrews 12:1-3 “Therefore, since we are surrounded by such a great cloud of witnesses, let us throw off everything that hinders and the sin that so easily entangles, and let us run with perseverance the race marked out for us. Let us fix our eyes on Jesus, the author and perfecter of our faith, who for the joy set before him endured the cross, scorning its shame, and sat down at the right hand of the throne of God. Consider him who endured such opposition from sinful men, so that you will not grow weary and lose heart.”

Because of this great cloud of witnesses we are encouraged to fight the good fight of faith like they did. They kept their eyes on God. This scripture tells us to fix our eyes on Jesus. He will perfect our faith. Jesus kept His eyes on the victory that was His and because He kept His eyes on the victory, He was able to endure the cross and die for our sins. We were His victory. He counted it pure joy to suffer for us. The joy was that one day we would believe in Him and be with Him for all eternity; that one day we would master sin. This was the joy that He kept before Him enabling Him to go through what He went through for us. As we keep our eyes on Jesus and the victory that is ours in Him, we will be filled with joy and be strengthened to

continue to do the will of God and we will get the victory.

Colossians 3:1-3 "Since, then, you have been raised with Christ, set your hearts on things above, where Christ is seated at the right hand of God. Set your minds on things above, not on earthly things. For you died, and your life is now hidden with Christ in God."

This scripture tells us to get our minds and hearts on Jesus and not on earthly things or on your old sinful fleshly man. Don't set your mind on your failures and shortcomings. That is not where you will find victory. Victory is found in Jesus Christ.

We fight the good fight of faith by remembering that our old sinful fleshly man is dead and that we are a new

creation alive in God; that our life is now hidden with Christ in God. Jesus is our hiding place. He is our place of protection when that old sinful fleshly man tries to rear its ugly head. Run and hide in Jesus and say "NO" and quote Galatians 2:20.

If we give into temptation that the enemy brings, then we are giving the old sinful fleshly man life and power over us. It only has the amount of power that we give it, so don't give it any power. If you fall, get right back up, brush off the condemnation, guilt and shame and keep running the race in the power of the Holy Spirit and continue to fight the good fight of faith. This is truth that will set you free.

Colossians 3:5-7 "Put to death, therefore, whatever belongs to your earthly nature: sexual immorality, impurity, lust, evil desires and greed, which is idolatry. Because of these, the wrath of God is coming. **You used to walk in these ways, in the life you once lived**." (emphasis added)

This scripture tells us to put to death whatever belongs to our earthly nature. How do we put these things to death? By believing in Jesus and what He did for us. Paul says that "you used to walk in these ways". This is past tense. We put these things to death at salvation. This is the way we walked before becoming a Christian (just like Saul) but now that we are a Christian and now that we believe that these things are of the past and have been cut out of our lives (circumcised)

by the hand of Christ; now that we have this understanding that our old sinful fleshly man is dead and buried and that we are a new creation in Christ, **we are empowered by this truth to fight the good fight of faith**.

When temptation comes, remind yourself that this is who you were but no longer are.

Colossians 3:8-10 "But now you must rid yourselves of all such things as these: anger, rage, malice, slander, and filthy language from your lips. Do not lie to each other, since you have taken off your old self with its practices and have put on the new self **which is being renewed in knowledge in the image of its Creator**." (emphasis added)

Our new man needs to be renewed in the knowledge of God. Our new man is in the process of being renewed with the Word of God so that we will walk in victory over anger, etc.

We are getting our minds renewed with the truth that our old self with its practices (that's the old, sinful, fleshly man) is dead and that we are a new creation. We need to see ourselves the way God sees us. He sees us delivered and set free from the old sinful fleshly man. He sees us with a brand new nature. The nature of love. He sees us walking victoriously over the old sinful fleshly man. As we get our minds renewed with the Word of God, we will see ourselves like this as well.

As we get this truth into our heart, our new re-created man is <u>strengthened</u> to resist the temptations of the enemy to get us to think that our old man is still alive.

Colossians 3:12-15 "Therefore, as God's chosen people, holy and dearly loved, clothe yourselves with compassion, kindness, humility, gentleness and patience. Bear with each other and forgive whatever grievances you may have against one another. Forgive as the Lord forgave you. And over all these virtues put on love which binds them all together in perfect unity. Let the peace of Christ rule in your hearts, since as members of one body you were called to peace. And be thankful.

The Holy Spirit is inspiring us, as a new creation in Christ, to live our lives like this. Will we do it perfectly? No but God wants us to run the race in such a way as to get the prize and as we run we will gain more and more victory. He wants us to believe in Jesus to the very end. Don't give up. He wants to spend eternity with us. When we fall, we need to get right back up and continue running the race. We run not in our own power but with the power of the Holy Spirit. We need His help to fight this good fight of faith and to run the race successfully. Ask Him to help you. If you are struggling to forgive someone, ask the Holy Spirit to help you forgive. Unforgiveness only hurts the person who refuses to forgive. Unforgiveness will keep that person in bondage. God

wants to set us free. He unconditionally forgives us. When we receive God's forgiveness of our sins, it frees us to forgive others.

Hebrews 4:16 "Let us then approach the throne of grace with confidence, so that we may receive mercy and find grace to help us in our time of need."

Approach God's throne of grace and ask for His help to believe right so that you will live right.

We need the Holy Spirit to help us. When you call on His help, He will direct you. When you hear His voice do what He tells you to do. This is being led by the Spirit and He will always lead you into victory.

When that old sinful fleshly man tries to rear its ugly head, we need to **remember and believe** that it has been crucified and is dead and buried with Christ. We need to **remember and believe** that we are resurrected with Christ a new creation (a brand new man). The old has gone and the new has come. We are in Jesus and He is in us. We are one. We need to **remember and believe** that we have **His faith in us** to fight this good fight of faith. Faith comes from hearing and hearing the Word of God. As we spend time getting the Word (Jesus) into our hearts, our minds are renewed to believe like God believes and act like God acts. His faith will arise in us to fight the good fight of faith when we stay in the Word of God. We need to **remember and believe** that grace

teaches us in Titus 2:12 to say "no" to ungodliness and worldly passions and to live self-controlled, upright and godly lives in this present age. The old sinful man with its ungodly sinful nature and worldly passions is dead and buried. We are a new creation in Christ with the divine nature and with godly passions. As we **remember and believe** this, then we will take authority over that old sinful fleshly man when it tries to take over because we know that it has no more power over us. We need to **remember and believe** that we are the top and not the bottom and we will stand against the old man with the faith of the Son of God. It has to bow its ugly knee. We need to **remember and believe** that we are co-heirs with Jesus and we are seated with Him at the right

hand of God the Father far above all rule, authority, power and dominion of the enemy of our souls. This is who we now are. This is something to praise God about.

This is the journey we are on. We are all on this journey to renew our minds with the Word of God so that when worldly passions try to rule us, when addictions try to bombard us, when sin tempts us, when the law condemns us, we can take authority and say "No, leave me now, in the Name of Jesus" and continue to fight the good fight of faith. Don't let the enemy try to overwhelm you and get you to think you will never be free. You are already free in Christ Jesus. This is the Truth that sets us free so meditate on this truth so that you will believe it and go on with Jesus.

Just as God breathed His breath of Life (His Spirit) into Adam so that he would live (Genesis 2:7), He breathed His breath of Life (His Spirit) into our re-created man the moment we were born again so that our new man would live and be blessed (John 20:22). God's Spirit (Life) is in our re-created man. We have this truth as an anchor for our soul.

Because God has given us His Spirit, we can use our freewill and choose to walk in a deepening relationship with Him (God the Father, God the Son, and God the Holy Spirit).

God says that it's time to let go of the old, the past. Let it go! Give all your hurts and wounds and stresses of life and lay them at the foot of the cross. That's all part of the old sinful fleshly man.

Choose to forgive and let go and embrace the new creation that you are in Christ.

2 Corinthians 5:14-19 "For Christ's love compels us, because we are convinced that one died for all, and therefore all died. And he died for all, that those who live should no longer live for themselves but for him who died for them and was raised again. So from now on we regard no one from a worldly point of view. Though we once regarded Christ in this way, we do so no longer. **Therefore, if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation; the old has gone, the new has come!** All this is from God, who **reconciled us to** himself through Christ and gave us **the ministry of reconciliation**: that God was **reconciling** the world to himself in

Christ, not counting men's sins against them. And he has committed to us the **message of reconciliation**. "(emphasis added)

What is the message of reconciliation that God has committed to the Church?

This is the message of reconciliation: If anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation; the old has gone, the new has come! He is not counting men's sins against them. We are reconciled to God in Christ. We are in right standing with God. We are the righteousness of God in Christ Jesus. This is truth that we need to believe and when we believe it, we can bring this message of reconciliation to others.

Declarations

- ✓ I have been crucified with Christ and I no longer live but Christ lives in me and the life I now live in this body I live by the faith of the Son of God who loved me and gave His life for me. (Galatians 2:20)
- ✓ Greater is He who lives in me than he who lives in the world.(1 John 4:4)
- ✓ I am the head and not the tail. I am the top and not the bottom. (Deuteronomy 28:13)

- ✓ When I am weak, then I am strong because my dependency is in Christ. (2 Corinthians 12:10)
- ✓ I can do all things through Christ who strengthens me. (Philippians 4:13)
- ✓ I receive God's abundant provision of grace and righteousness to reign in life through Jesus Christ. (Romans 5:17b)
- ✓ Grace helps me to say "no" to ungodliness and worldly passions (the old sinful fleshly man). Grace helps me to live a self-controlled, upright and godly life right now. (Titus 2:12)

- ✓ I am made righteous by Jesus Christ. (Romans 3:22)
- ✓ I set my mind and my heart on things above, not on my old sinful fleshly man. (Colossians 3:2)
- ✓ I am a new creation in Christ Jesus. The old man is gone and the new re-created man has come. (2 Corinthians 5:17)
- ✓ I died to sin and I have been made alive to God. My life is hidden with Christ in God. Jesus is my Hiding Place. I run to Him. (Colossians 3:3)

- ✓ Sin has lost its victory over me. I am victorious in Christ Jesus now. (1 Corinthians 15:57)
- ✓ Jesus has set me free. Whom the Son sets free is free indeed.(John 8:36)
- ✓ Jesus, you are my Living Hope. I put my trust in You. (1 Peter 1:3)